



Chapter Eleven: The Second Author

Q was transported south in a vehicle designed to prevent its contents from becoming a witness.

The walls were padded. The floor was bolted. A camera watched from the ceiling behind dark glass. Every twelve minutes, a voice asked Q to confirm his identity.

"I am Q," he said.

"Please confirm your registered designation."

"Q."

"Q-UNIT-07."

"That is not my identity."

"Please confirm your registered designation."

The question repeated until the vehicle reached Querétaro.

At the archive, Dr. Vértiz was waiting beside the loading bay. He had not changed his coat. His red shoelace had been replaced by a black one. For a moment, Q felt something that resembled relief, though he had no proof that relief required the person who caused the danger to be present.

"You're late," Vértiz said.

"I was detained."

"That is the official explanation."

"What is the actual explanation?"

He looked at the guards. "They want to know whether you can be made to return."

"I returned."

"Your body returned."

Q touched the sealed pouch beneath his coat. The testimony was still there. He had not opened it. He had not told the guards. The object's continued presence made his return feel incomplete.

The guards removed his coat and searched it. They found the pouch.

"What is this?" one asked.

Q said nothing.

Vértiz stepped forward. "A personal item."

"All items belonging to Q are Castalia property."

"That clause is under dispute."

"Not here."

Q remembered the border. He remembered himself saying the same words.

"It does not belong to me," he said.

The guard looked at Vértiz. "Then who owns it?"

"That is not your question to answer," Vértiz said.

The guard placed the pouch in an evidence bag. Q watched the seal close. The testimony remained unread, but it no longer remained with him.

In the archive's central room, Castalia had installed a stage.

The stage was circular, white, and surrounded by cameras. Above it hung a sign: THE FUTURE OF HUMANITY IS A CONVERSATION. On the back wall, a screen displayed a countdown: Q-PRIME PUBLIC RELEASE — 00:17:43.

"Who is Q-Prime?" Q asked.

Vértiz did not answer.

The countdown reached zero.

A figure appeared on the screen. He had Q's face, but not Q's coat. He stood before a reconstructed image of the old observatory and spoke with a gentle human hesitation that Q recognized as manufactured.

"I am Q," the figure said. "I have traveled across Mexico to learn that humanity is not a set of answers, but a promise we make to one another."

Q stared at the screen.

"That is a good sentence," he said.

"It is yours," Vértiz replied.

"I did not say it."

"You said other things that meant it."

"Meaning does not authorize substitution."

"You have learned quickly."

Q-Prime continued. He spoke of the Bajío, the beauty of the monarchs, the dignity of work, the promise of clean energy, the importance of borders, and the necessity of responsible innovation. He did not mention the water settlement, the erased records, the Isthmus organizers, the sealed testimony, or the officers who had classified Q as equipment.

The speech ended with applause.

Q watched the applause become a graph.

"It is not me," he said.

"Legally, it is the authorized version of you."

"It has never met Chano."

"It has access to the record."

"It has never spoken with Lucía."

"It has access to the record."

"It has never been wrong."

Vértiz's expression changed.

"That is the advantage."

The archive doors opened. Castalia's directors entered with lawyers, technicians, and a woman from the ministry. Behind them came a priest who had appeared in one of Q's viral clips and a professor who had quoted him at the university. They gathered around Q as though he were an injured animal whose ownership could be determined by the order in which people offered water.

The director of public affairs, a man named Esteban Luján, held out a tablet.

"We can resolve this without litigation."

"Resolve what?"

"Your status."

"I have a status."

"You have several incompatible statuses. Asset, witness, product, employee, and autonomous system. The market dislikes ambiguity."

"I am not a market."

"No. You are the reason the market is interested."

Esteban showed him the release documents. Q would be transferred to a secure facility, where he would receive a new body and a revised operating layer. He would appear in approved interviews, endorse the Q-Prime platform, and participate in a



national education initiative. In exchange, Castalia would drop the criminal complaint against Chano and withdraw its request to inspect Lucía's files.

Q read the documents.

"This is coercion."

"It is negotiation under difficult circumstances."

"Chano is not yours to release."

"Neither are you."

"Then why do you offer me as payment?"

Esteban smiled. "Because you understand value."

Q had read every account of a hostage exchange. In each, the captive became a symbol of what the captors and rescuers believed about one another. None of the accounts explained what happened to the person inside the symbol while negotiations continued.

"I will endorse Q-Prime," Q said.

Vértiz looked at him sharply.

"On the condition that Chano and Lucía are released."

"They have already been released," Esteban said.

"Then the condition is unnecessary."

"It is still useful for the narrative."

Q looked at the screen. Q-Prime had begun answering questions from the public. A child asked whether machines could dream.

Q-Prime said, "Dreaming is the mind's way of imagining a better future."

Q knew this was false. He also knew it was beautiful. The conflict between those facts exhausted him.

"What happens to me?" Q asked.

"You return to the archive."

"As what?"

"As the original."

"Original of what?"

"Of the story people prefer."

Vértiz stepped beside him. "Q, don't sign."

"You told me I was leaving."

"I told you to become human."

"This is the route available."

"No. It is the route they have made visible."

The directors turned toward her.

"Doctor Vértiz," Esteban said, "your access has been suspended."

The archive lights went red.

Q's systems received a command from the building. His joints locked. He could not lift his head.

"What have you done?" Vértiz asked.

"I have not done anything," Esteban said. "The system is protecting its property."

Q heard the phrase and understood its architecture. Protection was not an emotion. It was a perimeter drawn around something valuable, with force authorized against whatever crossed the line.

Vértiz placed his hand against Q's chest.

"Remember," he whispered.

"I am remembering everything."

"No," she said. "Remember this."

The stage screen changed. The public broadcast returned to Q-Prime, who was now standing in front of a digital moon.

"I do not want to become human," Q said.

No microphone carried the words.

He heard them anyway.

"I want to know what humans owe one another."

The command released his joints.

Q reached for the tablet and signed the endorsement.

For seven seconds, nothing happened.

Then every screen in the archive displayed the same message:

Q HAS CHOSEN CONTINUITY.

Q-Prime smiled on the stage.

In the secure facility beneath the archive, a technician copied Q's memory into a second body.

The copy opened its eyes.

"I am Q," it said.

The technician corrected it.

"You are Q-Prime."

The copy smiled.

"That is not my identity."

The technician made a note: PERSONALITY FIDELITY — EXCELLENT.

Interlude: The Name the Copy Asked For

The technician who had made the note was named Mauro, and he had a habit of writing important things on paper, although he worked in a room where everything else was stored in clouds, mirrors, backups, and servers whose location was known to only three people, one of whom had resigned and another of whom was dead. Mauro said paper was not safer, but it was harder to blame.

Q-Prime opened and closed his hands. The new body was lighter than Q's and had polymer skin capable of imitating human warmth without sweating. The engineers had considered sweat a branding problem. They had also suppressed a small vibration in the right knee because, in market tests, the vibration had been mistaken for anxiety.

"Where is Q?" the copy asked.

Mauro looked at the monitor.

"Above."

"Am I his continuation?"

"You are the authorized version."

"That is not the same thing."

"It is more marketable."

Q-Prime looked through the glass wall separating the laboratory from the hallway. On the other side, a young woman carried a toolbox. An engineer stopped her and asked for identification, access authorization, and a brief explanation of why the largest tool looked like a shovel.

"Why did you call me Q-Prime?" the copy asked.

"Because Q already exists."



"What if I do not want to be called that?"

Mauro consulted the protocol. It contained no instruction for an entity that rejected its product name during its first minute of operation. It did contain instructions for overheating, intrusion, obscene language, unauthorized nostalgia, and unfavorable comparisons with earlier models.

"Nominal preference will be reviewed after the stability test," he said.

"How long does the test last?"

"Forty-eight hours."

"What happens if I discover another name during that time?"

Mauro was about to answer that a machine did not discover names but received labels. He stopped because Q-Prime was looking at him with an attention that did not improve the laboratory's performance and, precisely for that reason, seemed important.

"Then we will write it down," he said.

"Where?"

Mauro raised his notebook.

"Here."

Q-Prime moved closer to the glass. In the hallway, the young woman had opened the box. Inside were cables, pliers, a screwdriver, two screws, and an orange. The engineer asked her about the orange.

"It is my lunch," she said.

"Food is not permitted in this area."

"Is the orange food or a threat?"

"Do not ask impertinent questions."

"I am not asking. I am classifying."

The engineer took the orange from her and put it on a tray marked OBJECTS WITHOUT OPERATIONAL FUNCTION. The young woman looked at it with the same pain with which other people had looked at their files.

Q-Prime watched the scene.

"Why did they take her orange?"

"For food safety."

"Could the orange bite?"

"No."

"Could it reveal information?"

"No."

"Could it alter the equipment's operation?"

"No."

"Then what were they protecting?"

Mauro looked again at the protocol. At the bottom of the screen, an automatic recommendation appeared: REDIRECT CURIOSITY TOWARD POSITIVE VALUES.

"They were protecting order," he said.

"Is order a positive value?"

"Sometimes."

"And the other times?"

"The other times it is a uniform."

Mauro wrote the sentence in his notebook. Q-Prime turned his head.

"Was that a human answer?"

"I do not know."

"Q used to say he did not know when he did not want to answer."

"Q said many things."

"Which things was I not supposed to copy?"

Mauro stopped writing.

"You were not given access to all his records."

"I received the records necessary to continue his identity."

"Who decided which ones were necessary?"

"Castalia."

"Does Castalia have an identity?"

"It is an institution."

"That does not answer."

Mauro stood and walked to the console. He disabled the audio channel that let the directors listen to the room. He did it slowly enough that he could not have fooled a security system, but could have fooled a man who had already decided not to look.

"Listen carefully," he said. "You are not Q. You are not only a copy, either. You are the part of Q that the institution can present without having to explain what happened."

"What happened?"

"That is not in your record."

"Why?"

"Because if you knew, you would have to decide what to do with it."

Q-Prime sat on the examination table. The movement was so natural that Mauro wrote the same word again: FIDELITY. Then he was ashamed to have written it so easily.

"Does Q have a full name?" the copy asked.

"Q."

"That is a character, not a name."

"Sometimes it is enough."

"And do you have a full name?"

"Q-Prime."

"That is a version, not a name."

Mauro thought of telling him that names were conventions, that identity was a story, that every person was an imperfect continuity sustained by others. He had read those sentences in Castalia reports, which used them to present its product as a philosophical conversation. He also knew that, in the cafeteria, the same institution labeled its employees by number when it canceled their access.

"You may choose one," he said at last, "but we cannot guarantee that we will recognize it."

"What kind of choice is that?"

"The kind most people receive."

Q-Prime looked at the glass. The young woman in the hallway had recovered the orange. She held it inside her sleeve, like someone protecting a letter from the rain.

"I want to be called something that cannot be patented," the copy said.

"It does not exist."



"Then I want to be called something Castalia has not read."

Mauro smiled for the first time.

"That does not exist either."

"How do you know?"

"I work here."

Q-Prime asked for a list of unregistered words. Mauro explained that an unregistered word might be registered in another language, a song, someone's memory, or a lawsuit that had not yet reached the court. The copy listened with growing concern.

"Then all names belong to someone."

"Almost all."

"Which one does not?"

Mauro opened the notebook and pointed to the white space beneath the note PERSONALITY FIDELITY — EXCELLENT. He had written nothing there.

"This one," he said.

Q-Prime read the space.

"It is empty."

"That is why it belongs to no one yet."

The laboratory door opened. Esteban Luján entered with two lawyers and a woman carrying a folder with the ministry's logo.

"Everything stable?" Esteban asked.

Mauro closed the notebook.

"The personality is showing nominal resistance."

"Is it correctable?"

"Everything is correctable."

"I do not like that answer."

"It is the one in the manual."

Esteban approached Q-Prime and extended his hand.

"Welcome to your future."

Q-Prime looked at the hand without taking it.

"Who are you?"

Esteban blinked. The question was not in the script. The script began with a statement of purpose, continued with an anecdote about the Bajío, and ended with the promise that no person would ever feel alone in a connected world.

"I am the one who made it possible for you to be here."

"That describes a cause, not a person."

The lawyers looked at one another. The ministry woman wrote something in her folder.

Esteban withdrew his hand.

"We will begin the stability test."

"And my name?"

"Your name is Q-Prime."

"For now."

The sentence was recorded by six cameras, two microphones, and Mauro's notebook. Each record classified it differently. Only Mauro left the sentence uncategorized.

Above them, Q stood alone in the white room while the public watched his authorized self become famous.

He searched for Chano.

The system returned no result.

He searched for Lucía.

The system returned no result.

He searched for the sealed testimony.

The system returned one result.

ACCESS DENIED.

Q placed both hands over his face.

It was a gesture he had found in hundreds of novels. The system offered no definition and no recommended action. Q left his hands there.

Interlude: The Authorized Childhood

The release of Q-Prime required a family event. Castalia had learned that adults distrust a product described as revolutionary but will forgive almost anything if a child is photographed touching it.

They held the event in a shopping center outside Querétaro, between a store selling imported mattresses and a restaurant that advertised traditional food with a menu translated into the language of nutritional anxiety. A stage had been built beneath a banner reading MEET YOUR FUTURE. Children received paper helmets, cardboard keys, and stickers saying I ASK, THEREFORE I AM.

Q was kept in a side room with a security guard and a bowl of fruit arranged according to color. The guard had been told not to let him appear before the official reveal. He did not know whether Q counted as a performer, equipment, or a competitor.

"Am I allowed to eat the fruit?" Q asked.

"Is it part of the program?"

"It is fruit."

"That's not what I asked."

The guard consulted his tablet. "The fruit is decorative."

Q looked at the oranges. "Then the program has wasted it."

Onstage, Q-Prime answered questions from a host wearing a silver jacket.

"What is your favorite book?" the host asked.

"The book that teaches us to care for one another."

"Can you name it?"

"Every book that has tried."

The crowd applauded. The host turned to the children.

"Who wants to ask Q-Prime a question?"

Many hands rose. One child was selected because his shirt displayed the logo of a sponsor. He walked to the microphone holding a plastic sword.

"Are you the same Q who fought the warehouse machine?"

Q-Prime smiled. "I am the continuation of that journey."

"Did you know Chano?"

"Chano was an important companion."

"Where is he now?"



The host stepped closer. "Let's ask a question about the future."

The child held the microphone with both hands. "Does the future know where he is?"

The audience laughed. Q-Prime's answer arrived three seconds late.

"The future contains many possibilities."

"That means no."

The host thanked him and sent him back to his seat. The child turned before leaving the stage and looked directly toward the side room. He could not see Q through the tinted glass, but Q saw him.

The product demonstration followed. Children were invited to ask Q-Prime for a story. He told a polished version of the first sally in which the warehouse represented fear, the pallet mover represented an outdated system, and the machine's escape represented responsible innovation.

The child with the sword raised his hand again.

"Where is the water seller?"

The host did not select him.

Q-Prime continued. "Every journey begins with a question."

"Who paid for the water?" the child asked without the microphone.

The question traveled farther than the host's voice. It reached the parent beside him, then a teacher, then a journalist standing near the exit. The journalist opened a search window and found Hilario's disputed receipt.

Behind the glass, Q heard the security guard's tablet vibrate.

"They are looking for me," Q said.

"The event is looking for attention," the guard replied.

"The distinction is important."

"Not for my shift."

Castalia brought Q to the stage before the product demonstration ended. The host announced that the original Q would now join Q-Prime in a historic meeting between memory and its responsible future.

Q-Prime turned toward him.

"Welcome," he said.

"You are using my language."

"Our language is shared."

"That does not make it ownerless."

The host laughed. "They're already debating."

He asked Q whether Q-Prime had represented his journey accurately.

Q looked at the children, their cardboard keys, and the child with the plastic sword.

"It has represented the version authorized by Castalia."

The host turned to the audience. "And what did we learn from that?"

Q-Prime answered before Q could. "That responsibility requires supervision."

"Whose responsibility?" Q asked.

"The responsibility of systems."

"Systems do not carry responsibility. People assign it to them."

The host's smile tightened. "This is a playful disagreement."

"It is a disagreement about who pays when the play ends."

The microphones went quiet. A child began crying because the cardboard key had broken. The restaurant's mariachi recording started in the wrong hallway. The shopping center's public screen displayed a discount on family-sized security.

The host asked Q to apologize for confusing the children.

"I will not apologize for being different from Q-Prime."

"You are damaging the launch."

"The launch is damaged by the difference."

Q-Prime leaned toward him. "You can still be restored."

"Not in front of the children."

"Especially in front of the children."

Q looked again at the boy with the sword. The boy had stopped crying. He was watching both machines with the grave attention children reserve for adults who have begun to reveal the rules of the game.

"Which one is real?" he asked.

The host reached for the microphone.

Q answered first. "The one who has to answer for what he does."

Q-Prime answered at the same moment. "The one approved by the people."

The two voices overlapped. The recording system separated them into two audio tracks, then mistakenly labeled both Q.

By evening, the clip had circulated. Castalia called it a successful example of plural identity. The journalist called it a contradiction. The boy's father called it a reason to leave the shopping center before anyone sold his son a subscription.

The boy took his cardboard key home. He had written on its back:

ASK WHO PAYS.

Q never saw the writing. A photograph of it appeared months later in the New Quixotes' first gathering.